

The wedding was canceled and I was destroyed. On the day of the supposed wedding I awoke to find my husband beside me in bed, his clothes ripped and in tatters and he unable to tell me where he had been for two weeks."

"The clerics that looked at him cleaned his wounds, for he had been attacked in the forest by some animal, and told me that he had lost so much blood that he couldn't remember the events of the last few weeks. The wedding was held a week later and it was after that my husband changed."

"Urtos became withdrawn and quiet, he seemed to be sad for no reason and he stopped working in his father's business. He became cold and distant not only to me, but his family and friends as well. He has barely spoken to his friend Gast since last summer and their friendship is no where near as strong as it once was. In the months that followed, Urtos spent more and more time up at the family hunting lodge on the edge of Ardeep Forest, telling all of us that he needed time alone. Last winter, his father grew sick very quickly and died before anyone knew he was gravely ill. My husband had spent the weekend at the lodge his father died, and was crushed when he returned home to find his father already buried in the family crypt. Urtos has been even colder and more secretive since."

"It has just gotten worse of late, and with the baby coming soon, I don't know what I should do. The rest of my family is living in Baldur's Gate and I could leave him, but then all my family's fortune would be lost and my child would have no father. I still do love Urtos and I know that the man I fell in love with is still inside the cold husk that he has become. If only I could understand what troubles him so..., I would do anything to help him get better. As you can see my friends, these questions and doubts hang heavy over me."

Allow the party to talk to Lythis further and let them ask questions. She knows little else than what she tells and will advise the characters to talk to others if they wish to learn more. She tells them to stay clear of Aridarye for she is a cold and cruel woman and she is better left alone. Lythis will halfheartedly query the characters about their lives over the past years but will eventually have to excuse herself to get some rest. She will have servants escort the characters to their rooms on the second floor of the old house and will tell them to meet her for dinner tonight in the dining hall. The characters may explore the city, check out the mansion, or rest until then.

Dinner

As the sun begins to set, you make your way into the southern mansion and to the dining hall. As you enter, you see a number of servants rushing around to set the table while four people stand in the Trophy Hall waiting.

Dinner is held that night at sundown in the dining hall in the south house. In attendance are Lythis, Gast Brokengulf, Aridarye, and her son Urtos the III. Urtos the II is conspicuously absent and Lythis wait a spell before telling the servants to begin to serve dinner. The meal consists of fresh venison and garden vegetables cooked into a stew. The dinner table will be uncomfortably quiet and the characters will notice that Aridarye has a sly smile across her face throughout the quiet meal. Observant characters will notice that Gast looks at Aridarye throughout the dinner, at times almost entranced by her beauty. Conversation will drift from Lythis' pregnancy, to Urtos III as he only eats the meat from his bowl, to the murder of a logger's family in Ardeep Forest. Urtos the II will return home halfway through the meal and apologize for being late, saying that he had already eaten. He excuses himself to his upstairs study and not be seen again this night. Lythis will excuse herself and follow him upstairs while Aridarye remarks how peaceful the villa has been in the past few weeks before laughing and leaving herself. Gast will follow her

out, leaving the characters alone with the boy as he stares at them with a dark smile.

Footsteps in the Night

Sooner or later the character will head off to bed and during the night read this to one of the characters;

It is the middle of the night when you wake from a fitful sleep to hear the soft padding of footsteps outside your door. The orange glow of lantern light sneaks through the crack underneath your door and it pauses before the footsteps begin again, heading for the stairs to the first floor.

Aridarye is making her nightly journey to her shrine in the family crypt. This should be a scary scene and the characters should be awakened and be curious enough to check out what is going on. Remember that dress and weapons are important to keep track of here as these items are probably stowed away. If the characters think of checking Aridarye's bedroom, they will find a sleeping Gast Brokengulf in her bed. If this happens, the DM will have to wing the encounter. Otherwise the characters can follow Aridarye quietly down to area 9 where she unlocks the north door and continues to her temple. The characters should have to deal with the doors in room 9 and 10 and then will be attacked by the watchspiders in area 27. Only after the watchspiders are dead will Aridarye emerge from area 30, supposedly visiting her husbands grave. She will be angry at the characters for killing the watchspiders and will tell them that Urtos the II will make them pay for the replacement cost. By this point, the night guards will arrive at the crypt with Urtos the II and he will order the characters back to their rooms, telling Aridarye not to venture down to the crypt at this time of night.

Morning

After last night's debacle in the family crypt, you feel that it may not be so good of an idea to show your face around the villa for a couple of hours. Gathering your things to take a journey into the city for awhile, you hear an argument in the southern house as you approach the front gate.

"You can't leave again Urtos! I need you here with me now. I'm am due to deliver your child any day now and I can't have you off brooding at the lodge, feeling sorry for yourself. I won't let you miss your child's birth like you did your father's death!"

There is an uncomfortable moment of silence before you hear Lythis continue, "I'm sorry my love, I did not mean..."

"Damn you woman, you will never understand...."

Urtos slams the double doors of the Sitting Room open and brushes past you angrily, heading out the front gate. You can see Lythis standing in tears in the room beyond. Out of the corner of your eye, you see the curtains on the third floor windows of northern mansion shift slightly.

Lythis is beside herself in grief and will need the party's sympathy. She tells them that Urtos and her got into a fight last night after the dinner and that he slept in his study apart from her. She tells them that she can bear it no longer and that she thinks that she will leave for Baldur's Gate as soon as her child is born. If comforted, she will admit that if she only knew what was going on, that she could help her husband become himself again. This should give the characters the idea of following Urtos through the city.

A Walk in the City

1) The Plinth (T38)

You follow Urtos easily, his long golden mane standing out against the browns and blacks of the crowds already on the streets of the city at this early hour. The mysterious nobleman heads due south towards the Trades Ward, his pace quick and never-tiring. A few turns down sidestreets and you see yourself standing in front of a multi-leveled tower reaching high into the morning sun. Even from the street you can hear the prayers and the songs coming from the building. Whatever this place is, it seems to be a temple of some sort and you watch as Urtos strides into its wide open doors.

This is the Plinth, a non-denominational temple that caters to the religious needs of visitors to Waterdeep. Visitors are asked to leave 1 sp each upon their exit to fund its maintenance. There are shrines to every known (and some almost unknown) deity in the realms within the temple, a quiet corner or private room within one of the many levels of the tower. Characters exploring the Plinth will find services of all types within but will find Urtos praying by himself to a bronze statue of Torm on the fourth floor. If the characters approach, they will be stopped by a priest of Torm, a cleric named Murien. Murien will tell the characters that Lord Phylund has asked for privacy and that they must wait to use the shrine. If questioned, he will tell the characters that Urtos comes here almost every day, since last summer, and prays earnestly to Torm asking forgiveness. By the looks of Urtos, crying softly as he prays, he must feel that he has committed some horrible sin. If the characters somehow interrupt the lord before he is finished (almost two hours later) or stop him on his way out, he will excuse himself politely and try to disappear into the crowd.

2) Mirt's Mansion

Urtos cuts westward through the streets of Waterdeep toward the docks as the noon sun climbs high over the city. The smell of fresh caught fish is strong in the air and you notice that the Dock Ward is a bit more run down than the finer areas in the northern reaches of the city. Urtos refuses to tarry at any of the shops or taverns in this area and you follow him through the fish markets and dingy alleyways to the far south western corner of the ward.

Here, in the shadow of Mt. Waterdeep the sounds of the fishmongers and street vendor drifts away and you find yourself amidst a quaint area of the city dominated by small taverns and homes secure in this miniature cove. Urtos continues with purpose toward the slopes of the mountain and walks up toward a stone mansion built into the cliffside. You watch from a distance as he knocks on the door as a beautiful blond haired woman in opens the door and ushers him inside. The door closes behind him and you are left alone in the streets.

This mansion belongs to Mirt the Merciless, otherwise known as Mirt the Moneylender, a secret lord of Waterdeep. Urtos has been liquidating his businesses in an effort to amass an investment fortune for his unborn child. By providing hard capital for Mirt's business (and unknowingly strengthening the city coffers), Urtos has bought a large "insurance policy" on his own life in the event he meets a violent death. Mirt is aware of the upcoming decision by the Lord's Court concerning the heir to the Phylund fortunes, and he is more than willing to help insure the unborn child's welfare if not his or her social position. Characters spying on or approaching the mansion will be spotted by Mirt's guards who will attempt to capture, incapacitate, and question the characters for their motives. Mirt's personal guards today consist of his wife Asper and a goodly frost giant named Harshnag.

Asper; CG hf F7; AC -1; hp 42; THACO 11; Dmg 1d8 + 4; longsword +2

Harshnag; CG frost giant male; AC 0; HD 14; hp 74; THACO 7; Dmg 2d8 + 9

Asper will ask for the characters surrender and if they resist, she will have Harshnag deal with the characters. If they surrender, or Harshnag has to beat them senseless, they will be ushered (or dragged) through a back door of the mansion, stripped of their weapons, and locked in a room until Mirt is finished with Urtos. After the young lord leaves, Asper will return their weapons and lead them into Mirt's study.

You are led by the lithe and beautiful warriorress out of you cell and down a carpeted hallway within the mansion. Beautiful swords, spears, and shield from all over Faerun hang from the walls of this mansion and art pieces from across the great oceans of Toril sit in every corner. This place is truly a palace in itself you think as your blond-haired captor leads you up a set of low stairs and into a darkened study.

This study is decorated with a dark red carpet and furniture made from a lovely grain of native duskwood. A large empty fireplace lies against the far wall and a great leather chair, its back turned toward you faces a window looking up at the magnificent slopes of Mt. Waterdeep.

A heavy, vibrating voice echoes through the room as the chair turns, revealing a tremendous bulk of a man, perhaps over 350 pounds with tiny yet sparkling blue eyes. "So, you ruffians have business with my friend Lord Phylund do you? I would advise you that the next time you call on Mirt the Moneylender that you knock on my door instead of spying on my from afar. I see you have met my wife Asper and it's a good thing that Harshnag was in a good mood or he might have sat on ya. For your information, I wasn't always a moneylender and in my day they called me Mirt the Merciless, and if know what's good for ya'selves you better start explaining what your doing here..."

Mirt has no intentions of getting physical with the characters, but he does want to make sure that they don't pose a threat to the city or Lord Phylund. When everything is explained, Mirt will tell the characters that Urtos is doing nothing improper, in fact, he has been liquidating his father's failing businesses and has been investing in Mirt's moneylending business. Mirt will tell the characters that all the interest that Urtos makes is going into a trust fund for his unborn child in the event that something might happen to the young lord before his child is born. Mirt sees no wrong-doing on the part of Urtos, and although he knows that the lycanthropy that infects Urtos is part of this, he realizes that he must keep this secret if Urtos' plans to create a fortune for his child are to succeed. Mirt will wish the characters a good day and tell them not to worry about the young lord, but if they won't believe him, they are more than likely to try to pick up his trail at the Twilight Hunter's Tavern, a bar that Gast and Urtos still patronize frequently.

3) Twilight Hunters (N26)

This brand new inn is located in the North Ward and seems to be a popular tavern with the nobles of the city. Swords, axes, shields, and various monster trophy heads line the walls and ceiling of this fine establishment. The taproom is filled with afternoon drinkers, all dressed in noble livery and spouting off tale tales and stories of lost treasures. The bar is run by a group of retired adventurers whose own trophies of battle and adventure are the ones that hang on the walls. The barkeep is a middle-aged woman whose name is Song, once (and

still) a powerful mage in the Northlands. Characters entering the Twilight Hunters will spot Gast Brokengulf sitting alone at the bar.

Gast will tell the characters that he is waiting for Urtos who sent him a message to meet him here but the characters are welcome to sit for a bit and drink some of the house favorite, orangeberry wine. Gast will gab about politics and brag about his recent fist fight with Lord Kuldos Roaringhorn, but will reveal some important information if pressed and slightly inebriated (despite his wealth, he'll insist the characters buy him a few rounds of his "orangeberry delight"). In regards to Aridarye, he will admit to an affair but will plead that the characters keep it a secret from Urtos and that it only has started recently because both he and the widow of the former lord are lonely. In regards to the hunting trip last summer, he will become quiet and then relate the tale;

"Last summer, after Shieldmeet, Urtos and I decided to take a few days off working the Trades Ward and go down to the lodge in Ardeep Forest for some hunting. Ardeep is one of the only woods around these parts that is still as our great-grandfathers found it, wild and natural, and more suited for the elves than we humans."

We had hunted there many times as young men and we would go on expeditions for weeks at a time if we were on the trail of a big stag or a bear. Last summer was different though, and the game seemed less plentiful than in years past. The sun started going down one evening and I, thoroughly rejected by missing a young buck at 50 yards, decided to head back to the lodge for a warm night by the fire. Urtos wasn't as dejected about the hunt as I however, and he told me he was going to sit out until the sun set and he would be right behind me. Understanding that he was to be married in a few weeks, I told him to hurry back to the lodge when he was ready, I thought he needed some time to himself before the wedding.

The problem was he didn't come back that night, nor did he return to the lodge in the morning. I hiked back to where I had last seen him the night before and there wasn't any sign of him. I searched the northern reaches of Ardeep Forest all day, checking the groves and hillocks that we usually hunt. Late that day I found his quiver, empty of arrows, next to a dried-out riverbed. There was blood smeared on the leather strap and I feared the worst. I knew something had happened to him so I rode my horse back to the city as quickly as possible and rose the guard to help me search.

They combed the forest as deep as they could for over a week, until the underbrush got so thick and gnarled that they had to turn back. Other than the quiver, no one found even the slightest trace of what happened to the young lord.

I'm sure Lythis has told you the rest, how my friend returned to Waterdeep sometime during the night before his wedding, dazed and wounded, despite the fact that not a city guard noted his entrance through the gates that evening. He hasn't been the same since, and other than the occasional drink we have here some nights, he barely speaks his mind to me. Somewhere, deep inside, I think he blames me for leaving him out there, and somewhere deep within myself, I think I blame me too..."

Gast is a true friend to Urtos and although he is involved with Aridarye he would never do anything to purposely hurt Lord Phylund. At the conclusion of their conversation, Urtos will enter the tavern and make his way over to the bar. He will be surprised at the characters presence, but will greet them politely and then ask if he can have a moment alone with his friend. Urtos will tell Gast that he is leaving the city for a few days and will ask his friend to watch over Lythis for him. His meeting is short and to the point and the characters will watch as Urtos begins to leave and Gast tries to stop him.